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Interkulturelle Kommunikation und heterogene Teams

Lecture Notes- 06: Digital Collaboration

- Challenges of virtual collaboration
- Appropriate collaboration tools
- Design communication norms for remote teams
- Improve trust and coordination in distributed teams



The Reality of Modern Teams

Why Does Digital Collaboration Matter?

Traditional Team

- Same office
- Face-to-face
- Shared culture
- Immediate feedback

Virtual Team

- Remote
- Digital communication
- Multiple cultures
- Different time zones
- Asynchronous work

Have you ever worked on a group project where everybody was not in the same room?



Why Does Digital Collaboration Matter?

Benefits

- More diverse expertise
- Global talent
- Flexibility
- Innovation
- Reduced travel
- 24-hour productivity

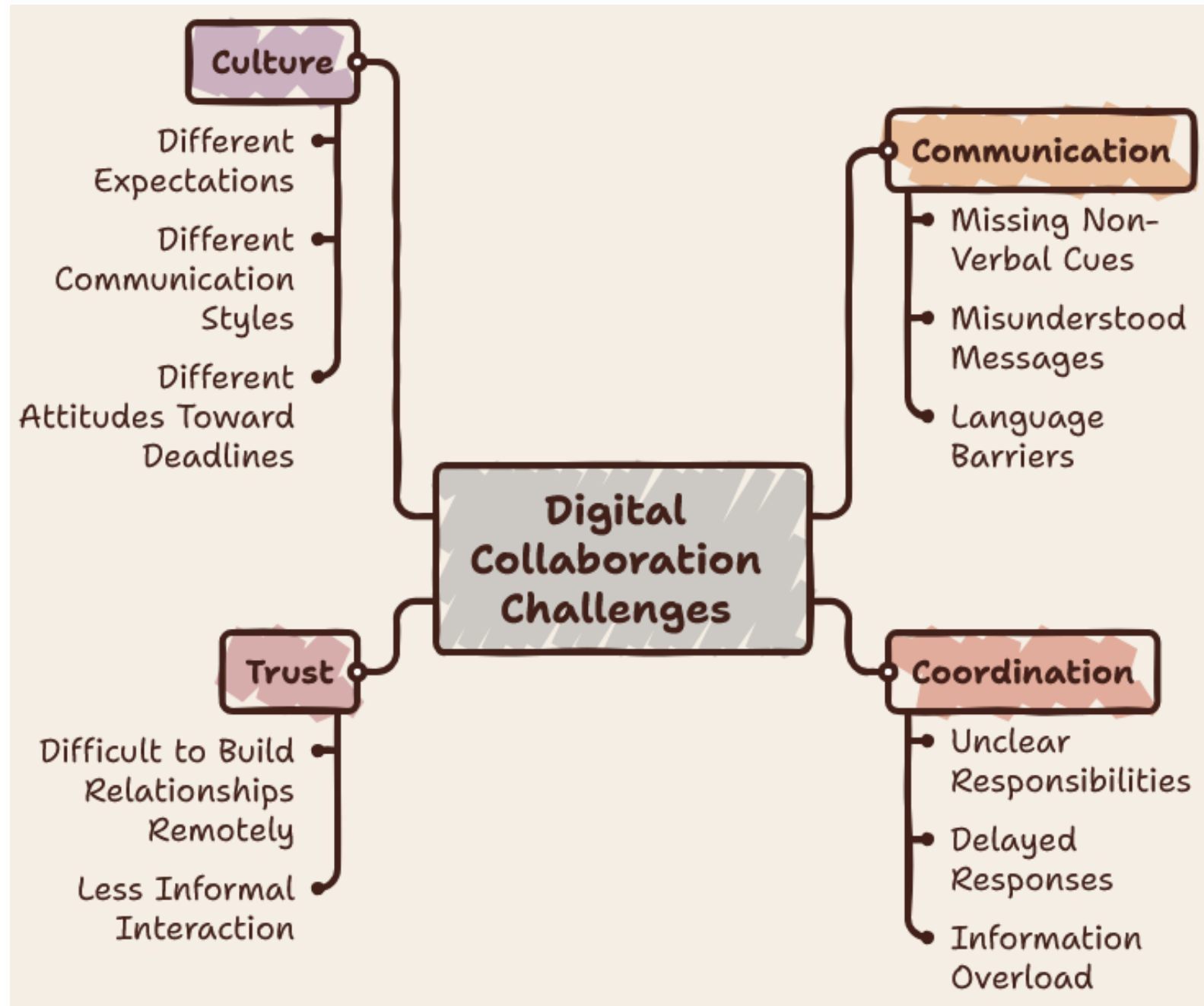
Challenges

- Communication delays
- **Lack** of trust
- Technology dependence
- Isolation
- Different communication expectations
- Cultural misunderstandings
- Information overload

Common Problems

The same **barriers** we have discussed earlier become **stronger** in **remote** teams.

Which challenge is probably the hardest?



Synchronous vs Asynchronous Communication

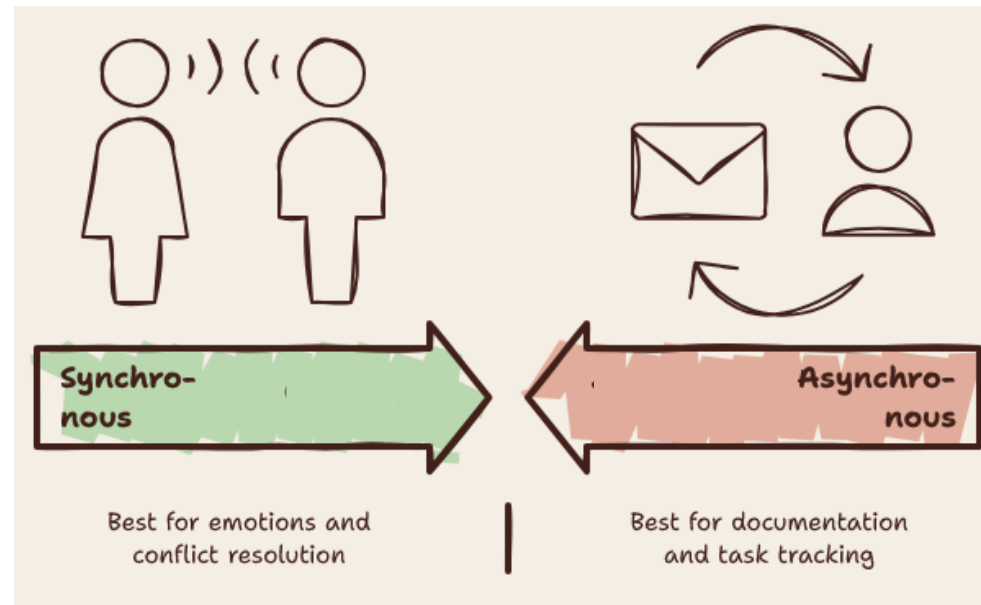
Synchronous Communication

Examples:

- Teams meetings
- Zoom calls
- Phone calls

Best for:

- emotions
- conflict resolution
- brainstorming
- relationship building



Asynchronous Communication

Examples:

- Email
- Teams chat
- Jira comments
- Shared documents

Best for:

- documentation
- updates
- task tracking

Digital communication removes many **non-verbal cues**.

Communication becomes:

- shorter
- faster
- more ambiguous

Channel	Best Use
Email	Formal communication
Chat	Quick questions
Video meetings	Complex discussions
Shared documents	Collaborative work
Project boards	Task coordination

Discussion point:
When is **email** better than chat?

Categories

Purpose	Examples
Communication	Teams, Zoom
Project Management	Jira, Trello, Asana
Documentation	SharePoint, OneDrive, Confluence
Collaboration	Miro, Whiteboard
Knowledge Sharing	Wikis, Teams Channels

Does technology solve collaboration problems?

→ Technology **supports** collaboration;
people create collaboration.

High-context cultures often prefer

- richer communication
- video
- relationship building

Low-context cultures often prefer

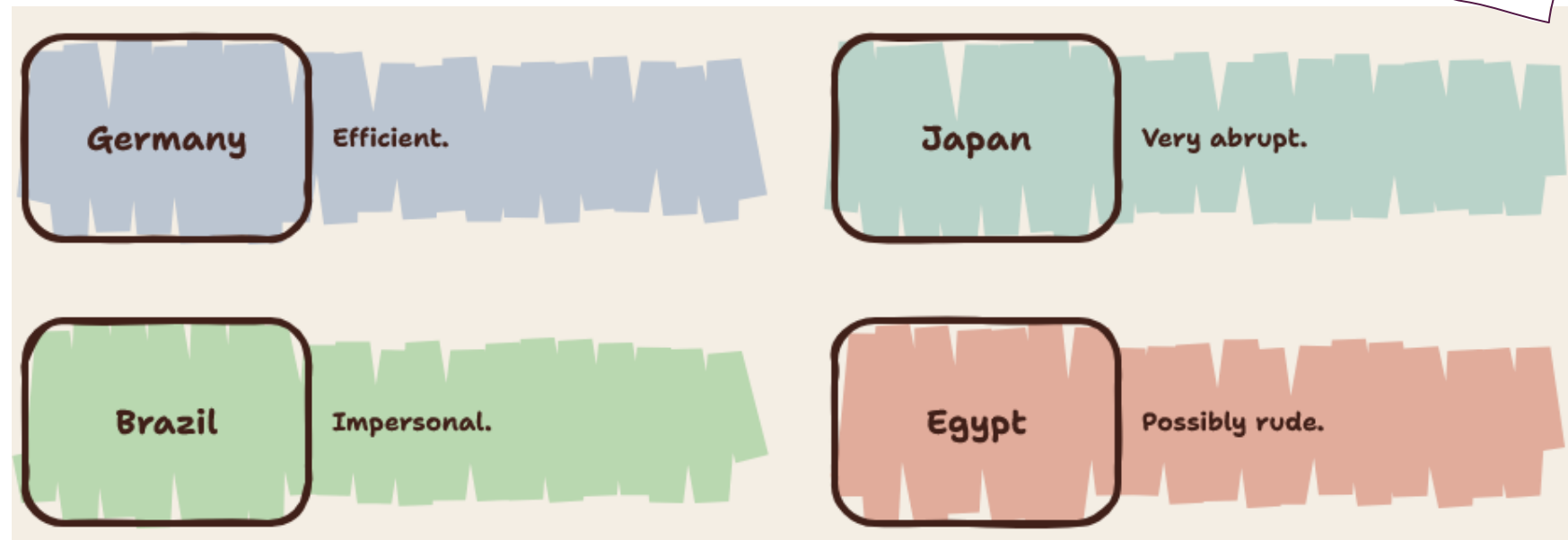
- concise written communication
- direct messages

Example:

A short **Teams** message:

"Please fix this."

Possible interpretations:



Activity - write your answer on Chat!

Rewrite **poorly** written digital messages into **culturally inclusive** versions.

Original:

“Need this ASAP”

Improved:

.....

Why Is Trust Harder Online?

Remote teams often **lack**:

- **informal** conversations
- **body** language
- **spontaneous** interaction

Building Trust

- reliability
- transparency
- responsiveness
- **respectful** communication

Psychological safety remains critical for inclusive teams.

Best Practices

- Use **explicit** language.
- **Avoid** slang.
- **Confirm** understanding.
- **Summarize** decisions.
- Use **cameras strategically**
- **Document** agreements.

Effective Teams

- Define **roles** clearly
- Use **shared** documentation
- Agree on communication **rules**
- Schedule **regular** check-ins
- Make decisions **transparent**
- Consider (respect) time **zones**
- **Rotate** meeting times.
- Encourage **inclusion**

GRPI still applies in **virtual** teams.

Practical Case Exercise: Global Teams



A **global** team is **developing** a mobile application.

Team members come from: Germany, Brazil, India, and United States



Challenges:

- Different time zones
- Different communication styles
- Tight deadlines
- New team members joining

Task

- Design the **team's collaboration strategy**.

Discuss:

- Which **communication tools** will you use?
- Which communication should be **synchronous**?
- Which communication should be **asynchronous**?
- How will you **build trust**?
- How will you **include** all team **members**?

AI in Intercultural Collaboration

Is AI a *tool*?
Or a *teammate*?

AI now **supports**

- brainstorming
- translation
- summarization
- coding
- meeting notes
- scheduling
- writing

Opportunities

- Language translation
- Grammar improvement
- Meeting summaries
- Knowledge sharing
- Idea generation
- Accessibility
- Reducing routine work

Risks

- **Bias**
- Hallucinations
- Loss of critical thinking
- Privacy
- Over-reliance
- Unequal AI access
- Cultural bias in AI outputs

Example

Prompt:

“ Write a polite email refusing a proposal.”

Ask AI:

- English
- German
- Japanese
- Arabic

Compare results.

How does **politeness** differ?

GenAI as a "Tone & Culture Translator"

Use Cases:

- **Direct to Diplomatic:**

Softening blunt German/Dutch feedback for Asian or Latin American partners.

- **Indirect to Actionable:**

Converting indirect **high-context** requests into explicit low-context action items.

- **Language Leveling:**

Helping non-native speakers express complex technical ideas clearly.

*Does AI translation build genuine **Cultural Intelligence (CQ)**,
or just outsource it?*

AI is trained mostly on

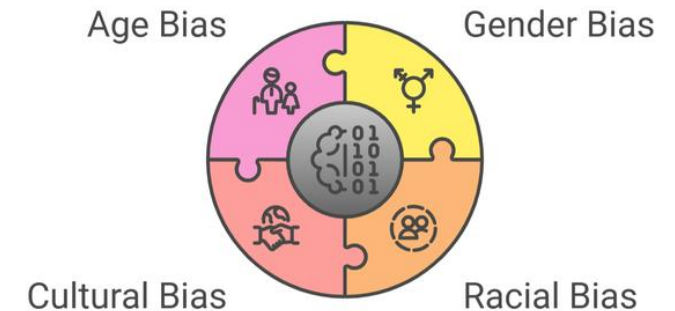
- English
- Western data
- Internet sources

How might this affect global collaboration?

Examples:

- Communication style
- Leadership advice
- Conflict resolution
- Negotiation
- Decision making

Evaluating AI Biases with Diverse Prompts



<https://www.linkedin.com/pulse/evaluating-cognitive-biases-ai-models-practical-approach-marhou-ondye/>

- **Western Bias – by nature:**

Most LLMs default to Anglo-American definitions of "**professionalism**" and "**assertiveness**."

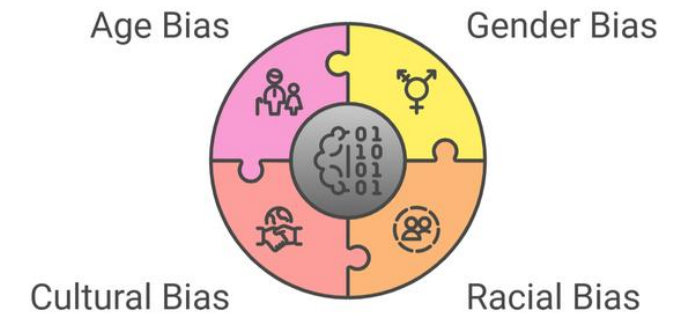
- **Dilution of Meaning:** [Loss of **Authentic** Intent]

Over-polishing via AI can dilute urgency and **hide real disagreements**.

- **Trust Loss:**

Unannounced AI recording/summary bots in meetings can **destroy psychological safety** in **high-uncertainty-avoidance** cultures.

Evaluating AI Biases with Diverse Prompts



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Key Takeaways!

Technology **does not eliminate** cultural differences → it changes **how** they are **expressed**.

Successful digital collaboration requires:

- Clear communication
- Cultural intelligence
- **Trust**
- Inclusive leadership
- Effective digital tools
- **Responsible AI use**



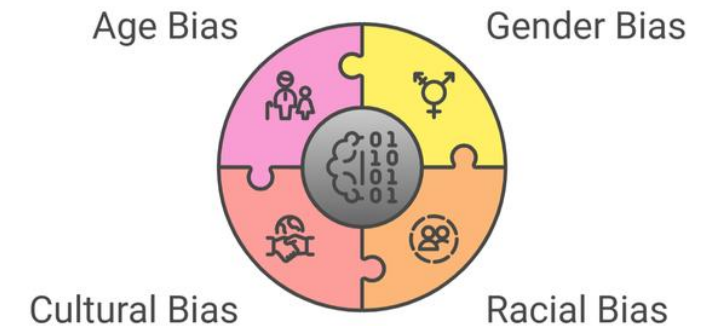
- **5 tips to build strong cross-cultural virtual teams**

<https://escp.eu/thechoice/tomorrow-choices/5-tips-to-build-strong-cross-cultural-virtual-teams/>

Evaluating AI Biases with Diverse Prompts

- **Evaluating Cognitive Biases in AI Models: A Practical Approach**

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A low-angle, blue-tinted photograph of a group of graduates in black gowns. They are all looking upwards with expressions of joy and excitement, their arms raised high. Several black graduation caps are captured mid-air, having just been tossed by the graduates. The background is a bright, clear sky.

**Use Case for the Report – Action →
work**



Any Questions ?